

Rui Wang, PhD

Department of Communication and Media, Loyola University Maryland

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Areas of Research and Expertise

Emerging Technologies; Political Communication; Social Media; Computational Social Science; Journalism

Academic Appointments

Assistant Professor 2025.7 - present

Loyola University Maryland, Department of Communication and Media

Lecturer 2018.7 - 2020.12

Anhui Normal University, School of Journalism and Communication

Education

Ph.D. Communication May 2025

University at Buffalo, The State University of New York

Chair: Dr. Yotam Ophir

Committee members: Dr. Nojin Kwak, Dr. Yini Zhang

Dissertation: *Is Journalistic AI the Solution to the News Trust Crisis?*

Exploring the Roles of Transparency, Identity, and Cognitive Heuristics

M.A. Information and Communication Studies May, 2018

Rutgers University – New Brunswick, The State University of New Jersey

B.A. Journalism July, 2016

Anhui Normal University, China

Graduate Experience

Graduate Research Assistant 2023.8 – 2025.5

University at Buffalo, Asia Research Institute

Supervisor: Nojin Kwak

Graduate Teaching Assistant 2021.9 - 2023.8

University at Buffalo, Department of Communication

Graduate Teaching Assistant 2017.1 - 2018.5

Rutgers University – New Brunswick, School of Information and Communication

Peer-Reviewed Publications (N = 12)

- Wang, R.**, Zhang, Y. (2025) Partisan Response to Trump's Media Bashing on Twitter: From Synergistic Amplification to Strategic Avoidance, Countering, and Retooling. *Journal of Information Technology and Politics*. [SSCI-indexed journal, 5Y IF: 3.3] [Article Link](#)
- Wang, R.**, Nikolaev, A., Semenov, A., Ophir, Y. (2025) Content Engagement Capacity: A Network-Based Approach for Evaluating the Ability of Frames to Facilitate Online Conversations. *Information, Communication and Society*. [SSCI-indexed journal, 5Y IF: 5.3] [Article Link](#)
- Zhang, Y., Suk, J., Yue, Z., Yang, D., **Wang, R.**, Dong, X., An, Z., & Joseph, K. (2025) How Cross-Platform and Cross-Media Content Sharing Practices Shape the Social Media Ecosystem: The Role of Center-Left and Right-Wing News, YouTube, and Twitter. *Journal of Quantitative Description: Digital media*. [Article Link](#)
- Wang, R.**, Ophir, Y. (2024) Behind the Black Box: The Moderating Role of the Machine Heuristic on the Effect of Transparency Information about Automated Journalism on Hostile Media Bias Perception. *Journalism*. [SSCI-indexed journal, 5Y IF: 3.3] [Article Link](#)
- Wang, R.**, Zhang, Y., Suk, J., Holland Levin, S. (2024) Empowered or Constrained in Platform Governance? An Analysis of Twitter Users' Responses to Elon Musk's Takeover. *Social Media + Society*. [SSCI-indexed journal, 5Y IF: 6.8] [Article Link](#)
- Li. M., Suk, J., Zhang, Y., Pevehouse, J., Sun, Y., Kwon, H., Lian, R., **Wang, R.**, Dong, X., Shah. D., (2024) Discursive Opportunities and Social Media Activism: A Cross-platform Analysis of #MeToo on Twitter, Facebook, and Reddit, 2017-2020. *New Media and Society*. [SSCI-indexed journal, 5Y IF: 7.0] [Article Link](#)
- Wang, R.**, Suresh, S.S, Ophir, Y. (2024) The Growing Partisan Politicization of Non-political Spaces: A Mixed-method Analysis of News App Reviews on Google Play between 2009-2022. *New Media and Society*. [SSCI-indexed journal, 5Y IF: 7.0] [Article Link](#)
- Wang, R.***, Ophir, Y.*, Walter, D*. (2024) Not All Bots Are Created Equal: The Impact of Bots Classification Techniques on Identification of Discursive Behaviors Around the Covid-19 Vaccine and Climate Change. *Social Science Computer Review*. [SSCI-indexed journal, 5Y IF: 3.9] [Article Link](#)
- Hu, J., **Wang, R.** (2023) Familiarity Breeds Trust? The Relationship between Dating App Use and Trust in Dating Algorithms via Algorithm Awareness and Critical Algorithm Perception. *International Journal of Human-Computer Interaction*, 1-12. [SSCI-indexed journal, 5Y IF: 4.7] [Article Link](#)
- Wang, R.** (2023) Regulating Platforms by Flew Terry [book review]. *Mobile Media & Communication*. [SSCI-indexed journal, 5Y IF: 4.3] [Article Link](#)
- Suk, J., Zhang, Y., Yue, Z., **Wang, R.**, Dong, X., Yang, D., Lian, R. (2023) When the Personal Becomes Political: Unpacking the Dynamics of Sexual Violence and Gender Justice Discourses across Four Social Media Platforms. *Communication Research*, 00936502231154146. [SSCI-indexed journal, 5Y IF: 5.9] [Article Link](#)
- Ophir, Y., Pruden, M. L., Walter, D., Lokmanoglu, A. D., Tebaldi, C., & **Wang, R.** (2022). Weaponizing reproductive rights: a mixed-method analysis of White nationalists' discussion of abortions online. *Information, Communication & Society*, 1-26. [SSCI-indexed journal, 5Y IF: 6.0] [Article Link](#)

Papers Under Review (N = 3)

* co-first author

- Wang, R.**, Ophir, Y. (under review) Can Professional or AI Fact-Checking Protect Trust in Journalism from Political Attacks? The Complex Roles of Source, Transparency, Ideology, and the Machine Heuristic
- Levin, S. H.*, **Wang, R.***, Seo, J., Leong, Y. Y., Bennett, E., Yang, D., Yang, Z., Chen, M., Zhang, Y., & Suk, J. (R&R). From #StayWoke to “Culture Wars”: How a Social Justice Discourse is Separately and Synergistically Politicized on Twitter and YouTube. *Revise and Resubmit in Political Communication*
- Suk, J., Zhang, Y., **Wang, R.**, Yang, D., Levin, H. S., Seo, J., Dong, X. (R&R) Temporal Dynamics of Politicization: Tracing the Evolution of Social Media Activism #MeToo in a Polarized Era.

Book Chapters ($N = 1$)

- Ophir, Y., Liu, A., Shah, P., **Wang, R.**, Acosta, N., & Gillis, S. (2024). Science and Health Journalism and Its Effects on Audiences. In Walsh-Childers, K. & McKinnon, M. (Eds.). *The Palgrave Handbook of Health and Science Journalism*. Palgrave & McMillan Publishing. [Article Link](#)

Manuscripts in Progress ($N = 6$)

- Wang, R.**, Seo, J., Yim, C., Levin, S. H., Romann, L., Suk, J., & Zhang, Y. (data collection). A cycle of contention: The politicized turn of discourse of AI on social media after ChatGPT.
- Wang, R.**, Liu, R., Mao, K., & Yang, C. (data collection). Apple Traitor and Huawei Patriot: A Multiplatform Analysis of the Politicization of Technology Brands in China
- Wang, R.**, Yang, J., Shah, P. (in final writing stage). Diffusion of obscurity: Unpacking the early discussion surrounding fast fashion on Twitter
- Raffloer, G. C., Kourtz, K., **Wang, R.**, Walter, D., & Ophir, Y. (in final writing stage). Approaching singularity: Topic modeling of public discourse on artificial intelligence over time
- Raffloer, G., **Wang, R.**, Thimmanayakanapalya, S. S., & Ophir, Y. (in final writing stage). Someone to talk to: A mixed-method analysis of human-machine communication features in chatbot app reviews and their association with ratings.
- Lapan, E., Ophir, Y., Kountz, K., Walter, D., Tenzek, K., **Wang, R.**, Nikolaev, A., Semenov, A. (in final writing stage). A Pill of Many Colors: Negotiating Extremist Red-Pill Ideologies on Reddit

Conference Papers and Presentations ($N = 27$)

- Lapan, E., Ophir, Y., **Wang, R.**, Kountz, K., Walter, D., Nikolaev, A., & Semenov, A. (2025). Negotiating extremism: Engagement capacity for red-pill conversations on Reddit. *Paper accepted for presentation at the 121st American Political Science Association Annual Meeting*, Vancouver, CA.
- Raffloer, G., **Wang, R.**, Thimmanayakanapalya, S. S., & Ophir, Y. (2025). Someone to talk to: A mixed-method analysis of human-machine communication features in chatbot app reviews and their association with ratings. *Paper accepted for presentation at the 75th Annual Conference of the International Communication Association*, Denver, U.S.
- Wang, R.**, Seo, J., Yim, C., Levin, S. H., Romann, L., Suk, J., & Zhang, Y. (2025). A cycle of contention: The politicized turn of discourse of AI on social media after ChatGPT. *Paper accepted for presentation at the 75th Annual Conference of the International Communication Association*, Denver, U.S.
- Wang, R.**, Nikolaev, A., Semenov, A., Ophir, Y. (2024) Content Engagement Capacity: A Network-Based Approach for Evaluating the Ability of Frames to Facilitate Online Conversations. Paper accepted for presentation at *107th Association for Education in Journalism and Mass Communication*, Philadelphia, PA, U.S.

- Wang, R.**, Zhang, Y., Suk, J., Holland Levin, S. (2024) Empowered or Constrained in Platform Governance? An Analysis of Twitter Users' Responses to Elon Musk's Takeover. Paper accepted for presentation at *107th Association for Education in Journalism and Mass Communication*, Philadelphia, PA, U.S.
- Wang, R.**, Zhang, Y. (2024) Partisan Response to Trump's Media Bashing on Twitter: From Synergistic Amplification to Strategic Avoidance, Countering, and Retooling. Paper accepted for presentation at *107th Association for Education in Journalism and Mass Communication*, Philadelphia, PA, U.S.
- Wang, R.***, Levin, S. H.*, Seo, J., Leong, Y. Y., Bennett, E., Yang, D., Yang, Z., Chen, M., Zhang, Y., & Suk, J. (2024). The politicization of "woke": A cross-platform study between 2012-2022. Paper accepted for presentation at *120th American Political Science Association Annual Meeting*, Philadelphia, PA, U.S.
- Lapan, E., Ophir, Y., Kountz, K., Walter, D., Tenzek, K., **Wang, R.**, Nikolaev, A., Semenov, A. (2024). A Pill of Many Colors: Negotiating Extremist Red-Pill Ideologies on Reddit. Paper accepted for presentation at *120th American Political Science Association Annual Meeting*, Philadelphia, PA, U.S.
- Raffloer, G., Ophir, Y., Thimmanayakanapalya, S. S., **Wang, R.** (2024). Best (Digital) Friends Forever: Topic Modeling and Cluster Analysis of Chatbot App Reviews. Paper accepted for presentation at *RIT Student Research in Communication Conference*.
- Wang, R.**, Yang, J., Shah, P., & Thimmanayakanapalya, S. S. (2024). Diffusion of obscurity: Unpacking the early discussion surrounding fast fashion on Twitter. Paper accepted for presentation at *74th Annual International Communication Association Conference*, Gold Cost, Australia.
- Levin, S*. H., **Wang, R.***, Seo, J., Leong, Y. Y., Bennett, E., Yang, D., Yang, Z., Chen, M., Zhang, Y., & Suk, J. (2024). From #StayWoke to "Culture Wars": How a Social Justice Discourse is Separately and Synergistically Politicized on Twitter and YouTube. Paper accepted for presentation at *74th Annual International Communication Association Conference*, Gold Cost, Australia.
- Raffloer, G. C., Kourtz, K., **Wang, R.**, Walter, D., & Ophir, Y. (2024). Approaching singularity: Topic modeling of public discourse on artificial intelligence over time. Paper accepted for presentation at *74th Annual International Communication Association Conference*, Gold Cost, Australia.
- Hu, J., **Wang, R.** (2023) Making Personal Choice with Algorithm Matchmakers, or Not? The Relationship between Dating App Usage and Algorithm Perceptions via Algorithm Awareness. Paper accepted for presentation at *108th National Communication Association*, National Harbor, MD, U.S.
- Wang, R.**, Ophir, Y. (2023) Intentions to Engage with Automated Journalism: The Impact of Authorship Cues, Algorithmic Transparency, and Knowledge. Paper accepted for presentation at *106th Association for Education in Journalism and Mass Communication*, Washington, D.C., U.S.
- Wang, R.**, Ophir, Y. (2023) Behind the Black Box: The Moderating Role of the Machine Heuristic on the Effect of Transparency Information about Automated Journalism on Hostile Media Bias Perception. Paper accepted for presentation at *106th Association for Education in Journalism and Mass Communication*, Washington, D.C., U.S.
- Wang, R.**, Zhang, Y. (2023) How Traditional Media and Partisan Influencers on Twitter Responded to Trump's Media Bashing. Paper accepted for presentation at *119th American Political Science Association Annual Meeting*, Los Angeles, CA, U.S.
- Wang, R.**, Nikolaev, A., Semenov, A., Ophir, Y. (2023) Examining the Influences of Twitter Bots During 2022 U.S. Midterm Election. Paper accepted for presentation at *119th American Political Science Association Annual Meeting*, Los Angeles, CA, U.S.
- Zhang, Y., Suk, J., Levin, S.H., **Wang, R.** (2023) Elon Musk, Platform Ownership, User Participation, and the Governance of Twitter. Paper accepted for presentation at *119th American Political Science Association Annual Meeting*, Los Angeles, CA, U.S.

- Wang, R.**, Ophir, Y. (2023) An AI Shield from Political Attacks: Testing the Potential of Artificial Intelligence-Based Fact-checking to Ameliorate Distrust in Mainstream Media. Paper accepted for presentation at *73rd Annual International Communication Association Conference*, Toronto, Ontario, Canada.
- Wang, R.**, Suresh, S, Ophir, Y. (2023) News Apps as Identity Politics: A Mixed-Method Analysis of the Politicized Online Reviews about News Apps on Google Play and Apple Store. Paper accepted for presentation at *73rd Annual International Communication Association Conference*, Toronto, Ontario, Canada.
- Suk, J., Zhang, Y., **Wang, R.**, Yang, D., Dong, X., Levin, S.H. & Seo, J. (2023) Fleeting Public Attention and Stubborn Partisan Passion: Politicization of #MeToo on Twitter. Paper accepted for presentation at *73rd Annual International Communication Association Conference*, Toronto, Ontario, Canada.
- Li, M., Suk, J., Sun, Y., Lian, R., Zhang, Y., Kwon, H., **Wang, R.**, Dong, X., Pevehouse, J., Shah, D. (2023) A Cross-platform Analysis of 2017-2020 #MeToo on Twitter, Facebook, and Reddit. Paper accepted for presentation at *73rd Annual International Communication Association Conference*, Toronto, Ontario, Canada.
- Wang, R.**, Ophir, Y., Walter, D. (2022). Twitter Bots and Polarization of COVID-19 Vaccine. Paper accepted for presentation at *118th American Political Science Association Annual Meeting*, Montréal, Québec, Canada.
- Wang, R.**, Ophir, Y. (2022). The Effect of Automated Journalism on Hostile Media Bias. Paper accepted for presentation at *118th American Political Science Association Annual Meeting*, Montréal, Québec, Canada.
- Wang, R.** (2022). How COVID-19 Vaccine Content Attributes Relate to Engagement and Why it Matters on TikTok? Paper accepted for presentation at *105th Association for Education in Journalism and Mass Communication*, Detroit, MI, U.S.
- Suk, J., Zhang, Y., Yue, Z., **Wang, R.**, Dong, X., Yang, D., Lian, R., Kwak, N. (2022). “The personal is political”: A cross-platform approach to how networked acknowledgment before and after #MeToo transforms into politicization. Paper accepted for presentation at *72nd International Communication Association*, Paris, France.
- Zhang, Y., Suk, J., An, Z., Yue, Z., Yang, D., **Wang, R.**, Dong, X., Joseph, K., Kwak, N. (2022). Mapping out Information Flow in the Social Media Ecosystem by Tracing Hyperlinks. Paper accepted for presentation at *107th National Communication Association*, New Orleans, Louisiana, U.S.

Teaching Experience

University at Buffalo, Department of Communication

2022 Fall/2023 Spring	COM337 Communication Theory [Lecturer]
2022 Spring	COM337 Communication Theory [Teaching Assistant]
2021 Fall	COM101 Introduction to Communication [Teaching Assistant]

Anhui Normal University, School of Journalism and Communication

2018 Fall/2019 Fall/2020 Spring	Communication Theory [Lecturer]
2019 Spring/2020 Spring	Data Journalism Visualization and Storytelling [Lecturer]
2018 Fall/2019 Fall	Web Development and Production [Lecturer]

Rutgers University, School of Information and Communication

2017 Spring/2017 Fall/ 2018
Spring

COMM101 Introduction to Information and Communication Processes
[Teaching Assistant]

Research Experience

Research Fellow

The Media Effects, Misinformation, and Extremism Lab, University at Buffalo

2020 – 2025, P.I: Yotam Ophir

Research Fellow

Communication and Emerging Media Lab, University at Buffalo

2021 – 2025, P.I: Yini Zhang

AR/VR Research Assistant

Rutgers University

Jan 2018 – May 2018, P.I.: John Pavlik

Grants

Office of International Education Research Grant (\$1,500)

2024

University at Buffalo

Information Technology and Politics Section Travel Grant (\$250)

2024

American Political Science Association

Department Small Research Grant (\$1,000)

2023

University at Buffalo, Department of Communication

Political Communication Section Travel Grant (\$450)

2023

American Political Science Association

Summer Research Funding (\$4,000)

2023

University at Buffalo, Department of Communication

First Generation Scholars Travel and Accessibility Grant (\$250)

2022

American Political Science Association

Department Small Research Grant (\$1,100)

2022

University at Buffalo, Department of Communication

Awards and Honors

Awards

- **Best Student Paper Award.** American Political Science Association, Information Technology and Politics Section (2023).

Scholarships

- **Graduate Teaching Assistantship**, University at Buffalo, Department of Communication, 2020-2025.
- **Graduate Teaching Assistantship**, Rutgers University – New Brunswick, NJ, School of Communication and Information, 2017-2018.

Service

Ad-hoc Journal Reviewer:

- Communication Research and Practice
- Convergence
- Environmental Communication
- Digital Journalism
- Health Communication
- Health Education and Behavior
- Information, Communication and Society
- International Journal of Press/Politics
- Journalism
- Journalism Studies
- Journal of Computational Social Science
- Journal of Health Communication
- Journal of Quantitative Description: Digital Media
- Media Psychology
- Mobile Media and Communication
- New Media & Society
- Science Communication
- Social Science Computer Review
- Telematics and Informatics

Conference Reviewer:

- National Communication Association:
 - Political Communication Division
- International Communication Association
 - Political Communication Division, Communication and Technology Division, Journalism Division; Computational Method Division; Human-Machine Communication Division
- Association for Education in Journalism and Mass Communication:
 - Mass Communication and Society Division, Communication Theory and Method Division

Conference Services:

- **Best Graduate Student Paper Award Committee:** Information Communication and Politics Section in American Political Science Association Annual Meeting (2024)
- **Graduate Assistant:** Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation (APEC) Study Center Conference (2023)
- **Graduate Assistant Organizer:** ICA pre-conference *Digital Asia* (2023, 2024, 2025)

Undergraduate Thesis Mentor

- School of Journalism and Communication, Anhui Normal University, 2020-2022, 14 students

Invited Talks and Interviews

Guest Speaker

- **Computational methods for communication research.** COM205 Research Methods, Undergraduate course at University at Buffalo (2025 Spring)

Workshops

- **Surviving and Thriving in the Competitive Academic Job Market.** Department of Communication, University at Buffalo (2025 Spring).
- **Creating Compelling Research Presentations.** Department of Communication Professional Development Workshop at University at Buffalo (2023 Fall).
- **Advice on University Communications' AI Guidelines.** University Communications, University at Buffalo (2023 Fall).

Professional Affiliations and Memberships

American Political Science Association
Association for Education in Journalism and Mass Communication
International Communication Association

Professional Experience

Journalist and News Production:

Student-Led Media Outlets Mentor and Professional Instructor, Anhui Normal University (2018-2020)
Student News Reporter, Anhui Normal University (2012 – 2015)
Local News Journalist Internship, Shijiazhuang TV Station (July 2014 – September 2014)
TV Program Editor Internship, Hebei Province TV Station (July 2013 – September 2013)

Advertisement and Marketing:

Social Media Strategist, Prevent Child Abuse-New Jersey (September 2016 – December 2016)
Branding Strategist Internship, Xinqiao Shengshi Culture & Communication (Beijing) Co. Ltd (June 2015 – October 2015)

Skills and Software

Methods: Natural Language Processing, Topic Modeling, Machine Learning, Network Analysis, Content Analysis, Structural Equation Modeling, Experimental Design, Surveys

Statistical Software: R (advanced), SPSS (advanced), Python (beginner)